

Briefing III — How to Travel in France: Customs, Culture & Everyday Life

The French Art of Everyday Life

One of the first things we'll notice when we arrive in France won't be a famous monument or a beautiful landscape.

It will be the pace.

Life simply moves a little differently.

Meals last longer.

People linger over coffee.

Families stroll through town squares in the evening.

Markets aren't hurried errands.

They're part of the rhythm of the week.

At first, it can feel almost as though the country is running in slow motion.

It isn't.

It's simply operating on a different set of priorities.

One of the things I love most about France is that it quietly encourages you to slow down.

Not because there's less to do.

Quite the opposite.

But because there is so much worth noticing.

Some of my favorite memories from France aren't the famous places at all.

They're enjoying a long dinner in Paris with no particular place to be afterward.

Discovering a bakery around the corner from our hotel and returning every morning because the bread was simply that good.

Watching old men play chess in a village square.

Enjoying a glass of wine while watching the waves crash in a Normandy seaside town.

Or catching the scent of lavender drifting across a Provençal meadow.

Those moments happened because we weren't trying to maximize every minute of every day.

France rewards curiosity.

It rewards wandering.

It rewards slowing down long enough to notice details.

As we travel, I hope we'll give ourselves permission to do exactly that.

We'll certainly visit remarkable places.

We'll climb cathedral towers.

We'll walk battlefields.

We'll explore museums.

But some of the memories we'll treasure most may come from moments we never planned at all.

So here's a small challenge for everyone.

Each day, try to notice one thing that isn't on the itinerary.

Maybe it's a doorway.

A conversation.

A market.

A café.

A musician performing in a square.

Or simply the way the evening light falls across an old stone building.

Those moments are often the greatest gift that travel has to offer.

Food Isn't Just Food

If there's one thing France is famous for around the world, it's food.

And while the reputation is certainly deserved, I think one of the biggest surprises we'll discover is that French food isn't necessarily complicated.

More often than not, it's remarkably simple.

Simple ingredients.

Simple preparation.

Extraordinary attention to quality.

One of the great pleasures of traveling through France is discovering how seriously people take everyday meals.

Bread isn't just something that comes before dinner.

It's expected to be fresh.

Cheese isn't an appetizer reserved for special occasions.

It's simply part of life.

Markets aren't tourist attractions.

They're where people buy dinner.

Even something as ordinary as butter somehow seems to taste better.

One of the things I hope we'll all do is become regular visitors to neighborhood bakeries.

There is something wonderful about walking a few blocks each morning to pick up a warm baguette or a few pastries that came out of the oven only minutes earlier.

It's a small daily ritual, but after a few days it begins to feel wonderfully normal.

We'll also discover that French meals are rarely rushed.

Dinner often lasts two hours or more.

Not because service is slow, but because no one is trying to hurry you out the door.

The table is where families gather.

Friends catch up.

Stories are shared.

Conversation matters just as much as the meal itself.

One thing that may surprise us is how hearty much of French cooking actually is.

Yes, there are elegant restaurants and beautifully presented dishes.

But there are also comforting classics that feel immediately familiar.

A perfectly cooked steak frites.

A roast chicken with crispy potatoes.

A rich beef stew that has been simmering for hours.

Fresh seafood along the coast.

Simple omelets made with incredible butter.

French cuisine isn't about making food complicated.

It's about making familiar food exceptionally well.

One of my own favorite meals in France wasn't especially elaborate.

It was a perfectly cooked steak frites at a Parisian bistro, accompanied by a glass of house red wine.

There wasn't a foam, a drizzle, or a tower of ingredients balanced on the plate.

Just excellent beef, crisp frites, a wonderfully rich sauce, good bread, and wine that somehow tasted even better because we were sitting in Paris watching the city pass by.

Sometimes the simplest meals become the most memorable.

French chefs also understand the importance of what accompanies a dish. A well-made sauce—perhaps peppercorn, Béarnaise, or a simple pan sauce—can turn an excellent piece of meat or fish into something unforgettable.

Another thing we'll notice is that meals tend to unfold at a comfortable pace.

No one will rush us to order.

Water glasses won't constantly be refilled.

The check usually won't appear until we ask for it.

At first, that may feel unusual.

By the end of the trip, I suspect many of us will wish restaurants at home worked the same way.

So here's another small challenge.

Try something you've never eaten before.

Order the daily special even if you can't pronounce it perfectly.

Visit the neighborhood market.

Buy a cheese you've never heard of.

Share desserts.

Ask for a recommendation.

Some meals will undoubtedly be outstanding.

Others may simply be good.

But I have a feeling that years from now, what we'll remember most won't be whether a particular meal deserved a Michelin star.

We'll remember the conversations around the table.

The laughter.

The fresh bread still warm from the bakery.

And the simple pleasure of slowing down long enough to enjoy a meal together.

Everyday Customs

By now we've talked about France's history, its regions, and even its food.

Before we arrive, though, it's worth spending a few minutes on some of the little customs that make everyday life in France feel a bit different from what we're used to.

None of these are difficult.

In fact, they're part of what makes traveling there so enjoyable.

Probably the single most important word we'll use all day is one we already know.

Bonjour.

In France, it's customary to greet someone before asking a question or making a purchase.

Whether we're walking into a bakery, a small shop, or even asking someone for directions, beginning with a friendly "Bonjour" is considered polite.

It's a simple gesture, but it sets the tone for every interaction.

The good news is that we've got a secret advantage.

Kate speaks French fluently. Reese is the resident Tussey French speaker. Caroline is a little rusty, but I hope she gives it a try. Nate and Abby have been taking French as well, so maybe they'll surprise us.

But this doesn't mean Kate will have to do all the talking.

Far from it.

I hope all of us will try a few words whenever we have the chance.

Even if our pronunciation isn't perfect, people almost always appreciate the effort.

One of the nicest surprises we've found over the years is that many French people become even warmer once they realize you're making an honest attempt to speak their language.

We'll notice other small differences too.

I mentioned earlier that restaurant servers won't constantly check on the table.

Not because they're inattentive.

Because they assume you're enjoying your meal and don't want to interrupt the conversation.

If we're ready for the check, we'll usually need to ask for it.

Shops may close for lunch.

Some stores may also be closed on Sundays. In fact, Kate and I nearly ran out of gas driving to Paris in 2008 because we discovered—just a little too late—that many countryside gas stations were closed. It's a mistake we've only made once!

Public transportation is generally quiet.

People tend to speak a little more softly than we're accustomed to.

And that's perfectly fine.

Every country has its own rhythm.

Part of the fun is learning that rhythm rather than expecting it to match our own.

We'll quickly learn the difference between *eau plate* (still water) and *eau gazeuse* (sparkling water). Odds are at least one of us will order the wrong one before the trip is over.

Someone may discover that ice is far less common than it is at home.

We'll almost certainly encounter a bathroom or two that works a little differently than expected.

Those little surprises are all part of traveling.

Rather than worrying about getting everything exactly right, I hope we'll approach each day with curiosity and a sense of humor.

If we accidentally break a small social custom, life will go on.

We'll smile.

We'll learn.

We'll do a little better the next time.

In fact, I think that's one of the great joys of travel.

For a little while, we get to see the world through someone else's everyday routine.

What seems unusual to us is completely ordinary to them.

And before long, some of those customs begin to feel surprisingly natural.

By the end of the trip, I wouldn't be at all surprised if "Bonjour" starts coming out automatically whenever we walk into a shop.

And if that happens, we'll know we've started to experience France not just as visitors, but as temporary neighbors.

What Makes France...France

By now, you may be wondering what ties all of these experiences together.

The slower pace.

The neighborhood bakeries.

The village markets.

The cafés.

The centuries-old churches.

The beautifully preserved towns.

What makes France feel so distinctly...French?

I think one answer is that the French have made a remarkable decision over many generations.

They've chosen not to replace their past.

They've chosen to live alongside it.

Throughout our trip, we'll walk streets that have been in use for hundreds of years.

We'll shop in markets that have served their communities for generations.

We'll eat in restaurants housed inside buildings that are older than our own country.

We'll cross bridges built long before anyone imagined automobiles.

None of these places exist because they were preserved as museums.

They exist because people never stopped living there.

History isn't separated from everyday life.

It's woven into it.

We'll also notice something else.

Every village has its own character.

Its own church.

Its own bakery.

Its own weekly market.

Its own traditions.

The people who live there are often deeply proud of their local identity, while also being proudly French.

That's one of the reasons traveling across France is so rewarding.

The country isn't trying to make every place look the same.

It celebrates the differences.

Perhaps that's the greatest lesson France has to offer.

A place doesn't become interesting because everything is new.

It becomes interesting because each generation adds another layer without erasing the ones that came before.

As we travel together, I hope we'll notice those layers.

The Roman stones built into medieval walls.

The medieval churches standing beside lively cafés.

The centuries-old town squares filled with children playing after school.

The farmers' markets held in places where markets have been held for hundreds of years.

Past and present aren't competing with one another.

They're simply sharing the same space.

Maybe that's one of the reasons France feels timeless.

Not because time has stood still.

But because every generation has found a way to add its own chapter without forgetting the story that came before.

The Traveler's Mindset

As we wrap up this briefing, I'd like to leave everyone with one final thought.

When we think back on great trips we've taken, we rarely remember them because we checked every box on an itinerary.

We remember them because of how they made us feel.

A conversation that lasted longer than expected.

A view we weren't anticipating.

A meal that turned into an entire evening.

A wrong turn that led somewhere wonderful.

The best travel usually happens in the spaces between the plans.

France is an extraordinary country, and we're fortunate to have the opportunity to experience so much of it together.

We'll see famous landmarks.

We'll stand where history changed the world.

We'll visit museums, cathedrals, beaches, villages, vineyards, and markets.

But I'd encourage all of us not to measure the success of this trip by how many places we visit.

Instead, let's measure it by how fully we experience the places we do visit.

Let's put our phones away once in a while.

Let's linger a little longer over dinner.

Let's ask questions.

Let's notice the small things.

Let's be willing to wander down a side street simply because it looks interesting.

Let's sit in a café without feeling the need to hurry somewhere else.

Most of all, let's enjoy being together.

This trip isn't simply about seeing France.

It's about sharing an adventure as a family.

Years from now, I suspect none of us will remember exactly what we did on Tuesday afternoon or whether we visited one more museum than we had planned.

But I hope we'll remember laughing around a dinner table.

Swimming together after a hot afternoon exploring Provence.

Watching the kids discover something for the first time.

Sharing stories during a long drive through the French countryside.

Watching the sun set over the Mediterranean with a glass of rosé—or lemonade—in our hands.

Those are the moments that become family history.

Every generation has its stories.

This trip will become one of ours.

So over the next two weeks, let's be curious.

Let's be patient.

Let's embrace the unexpected.

Let's say "yes" to experiences we didn't plan.

Let's appreciate not only the remarkable country we're visiting, but also the remarkable opportunity we have to experience it together.

Because in the end, the greatest souvenir we bring home won't be something we pack in a suitcase.

It will be the memories we've created with one another.

In our next briefing, we'll leave philosophy behind and begin our journey in earnest, traveling west from Paris into Brittany and Normandy, where we'll discover dramatic coastlines, medieval villages, Viking legacies, and the events that forever linked France and America.

Until then, *à bientôt*.